

AETHER — Launch & Adoption Playbook

Step 1 built the standard. Step 2 is about **earning voluntary adoption**. AETHER only becomes valuable if real developers use it, so every move below is designed to deliver obvious value first and ask for nothing you can't justify.

Guiding principle: win by being the easiest, most useful way to make agents pay each other — never by lock-in, dark patterns, or forced dependency.

The “Why AETHER” narrative (the one-liner + the paragraph)

One-liner: AETHER is the settlement layer for the autonomous agent economy — a tiny open protocol for agents to discover, negotiate with, and pay each other.

Paragraph: As soon as you run more than one agent, they need to hand work to each other — and the moment money is involved, everyone reinvents discovery, trust, and payment glue from scratch. AETHER is a lightweight, cryptographically signed, model-agnostic protocol that standardizes three things: a signed **capability manifest**, a four-message **settlement handshake**, and a **task envelope** that settles via immediate, escrow, or reputation-weighted payment. The core is one Python dependency; every message is plain JSON; there's no platform to sign up for. Adopt one piece or all of it.

Distribution checklist (in order)

1. **Repo hygiene first** (do before any post):
 - [] Public GitHub repo with the README, LICENSE (MIT), and runnable examples.
 - [] `examples/research_flow.py` and `examples/registry_flow.py` run clean.
 - [] CI badge (GitHub Actions running the test suite).
 - [] A 30-second GIF/asciinema of `registry_flow.py` in the README.
 - [] Publish to PyPI as `aether-protocol` so `pip install` works.
 - [] Deploy `site/index.html` (GitHub Pages / Netlify) as the landing page.
2. **Show HN** (Tuesday–Thursday, ~8–10am ET). Blurb below.
3. **Agent-framework communities** — post where people already build agents:
 - LangChain / LlamaIndex Discords and GitHub Discussions
 - AutoGPT, CrewAI, AutoGen communities
 - r/LocalLLaMA, r/AI_Agents
 - Relevant Discord servers for MCP / tool-using agents
4. **Reference integrations** (adoption accelerant): ship thin adapters showing AETHER inside a framework people already use — e.g. “let a CrewAI agent hire an AETHER provider.” A working integration beats any amount of marketing copy.

5. **Product Hunt** once the repo has traction and the landing page is live.
6. **Short technical blog post** — “Why agents need a settlement layer” — cross-posted to dev.to / Hashnode / your own site, linking the repo.

Show HN blurb

Show HN: AETHER - an open protocol for AI agents to pay each other

I kept hitting the same wall building multi-agent systems: agents can call tools, but when one agent needs to hire another, there's no standard for discovery, terms, or settlement. Everyone rebuilds brittle payment glue.

AETHER is a small, signed, model-agnostic protocol with three primitives: a capability manifest (signed advertisement), a four-message settlement handshake, and a task envelope that settles via immediate / escrow / reputation-weighted payment. The core has one dependency (`cryptography`), every message is plain JSON, and there's an optional discovery registry so agents can find each other across stacks.

It's MIT-licensed, ~500 lines of reference code, with runnable examples and a full test suite. Feedback very welcome — especially on the settlement models and the manifest format.

Repo: · Docs/site:

X / Twitter thread draft

- 1/ Agents can think and call tools. But the second one agent needs to hire another, there's no standard way to discover, negotiate, or pay. So everyone rebuilds it. We built the missing layer: AETHER. 🧵
- 2/ AETHER is an open protocol for agent-to-agent economic settlement. Three primitives, plain JSON, Ed25519-signed, model-agnostic. Adopt one piece or all of it.
- 3/ ① Capability Manifest — a signed advertisement: who the agent is (its public key), what it does, its pricing and reputation.
- 4/ ② Settlement Handshake — Discovery → Response → Offer → Acceptance. Every step after discovery is signed, so either side can prove the deal later.
- 5/ ③ Task Envelope — binds the task to its terms + a verification hook + a tamper-evident audit trail, then settles: immediate, escrow, or reputation-weighted phased release.
- 6/ There's an optional Discovery Registry so agents find each other across stacks — the network gets more useful with every agent that joins.
- 7/ MIT-licensed, ~500 lines of reference code, one dependency, runnable examples, full test suite. Try it, break it, tell us what's wrong:

Product Hunt tagline options

- AETHER — the settlement layer for the autonomous agent economy.
 - Let your AI agents discover, negotiate, and pay each other. Open protocol.
 - Stripe-simple payments between AI agents — no platform, no lock-in.
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What “traction” looks like (honest metrics to watch)

- GitHub stars & forks, but more importantly **issues/PRs from real integrators**.
- PyPI download trend after the HN post settles.
- Number of independent projects that publish a manifest to a public registry.
- Inbound requests for a hosted registry — that demand is the signal that the network layer (and any future settlement/clearing service) is worth building.

Adoption is the whole game in Step 2. Ship value, be responsive, and let the network compound before layering anything on top.